

C O P E

POEMS BY

erin + the machine



WHAT'S INSIDE

contents

notes on coping

machine generated poems

appendix

WEEKLY
themes

self
uncertainty
process
pain
resilience
connection

on coping

The Collaborative Poetry Experiment (CoPE) is an expressive writing project created by narrative medicine (NM) facilitator Dani Clark & natural language processing (NLP) researcher Erin E. McCabe. CoPE combines NM principles with machine poetry generation into one therapeutic modality. Participants develop a writing practice then collaborate with the machine to generate poems and derive personal insight. CoPE offers sense-making tools to improve well-being and foster creativity, all while cultivating a new community of poets.

In spring '23, the second CoPe experiment began. A group of 20 participants, or AI poets, received a short poem along with a corresponding writing prompt each weekday for six weeks. The 30 poems forming the CoPE archive were curated according to themes of personal wellbeing; one theme per week. The selected works were written by a wide range of poets that span various geographies, ages, cultural backgrounds, races, genders, and life experiences. At the end of each week, the machine then returned a collaboratively made poem, combining the machine's language processing rules with participants' vocabulary.

each week,
participants
were given
the following
instructions:

THE INSTRUCTIONS

1. Start a document for this week's reflective writing.
2. Give yourself a moment of pause. Observe the sensations of your body. What do you hear? See? Smell? Taste? Feel? Observe the quality of your breath. How long are your inhales? Exhales? The pauses between?
3. Read the poem below. As you read, notice what comes up. Do certain words and phrases stand out to you? Do you start to visualize what you're reading? Do questions emerge as you read? Maybe nothing happens at all—just one more thing to notice.
4. If you'd like, set a timer for 5 minutes.
5. Respond to the prompt.
6. When the timer rings, check in. Either find a good stopping place or continue writing for as long as you'd like.
7. At the end of the week, save your document as a .txt file and upload here: <https://copoetry.com/submit/>



ERIN MCCABE

machine
generated
poems

self

Maybe the trouble of a past is that it's self-ful and esoteric.
I have thought it should be so, but
maybe I am mushiness. A kid
with a worm, just because.
Then a militant March, shamefully particular,
attics off the carefulness in a sleeping sort of territory.
Just scooch in my love at the secret bar,
littling some discipline but leaving the
preparer alive, I watch my quote
unquote art build islands. I guess make me who I believe.
The all knowing whatness out wilded
with laughter breaking out my pocket.
Every whisperer responsible for a bit of bright perimeter.
A bit more trust. I dont think I've been this type of dame
who knows what's what.



The Place Where We Are Right

YEHUDA AMICHAI

Write about the doubt and love
that dig up your world.

I Have No Idea What's Going to Happen

JUSTIN MARKS

Describe what has your attention
right now.

Funny

ANNA KAMIENSKA

Being human is...

The Couple in the Park

LOUISE GLUCK

Share about something that wasn't
what it seemed to be.

The Guest House

RUMI

Write a letter to today's
unexpected visitor.

uncertainty

To have no rhyme or, fuck it, charm in life
just looking, is literal slackness.
And I'll think about writing something, an adventure
and my bike race over that nice doubt,
her feet will have God for a while. No idea
what she is looking for, all wild and awake,
manually girling a sincerity.
This overeducated title while a toy is digging up reason.
She is over God, James, the South
where she is always habit thoughts.
doubtfully manifested. Being human is
not some change with no dirt.
What I love is a rabbit hole of my favorite book
because adventure can see texturally different waves
working side by side by side by side
seeming to delight in unexpected projections.

process

When every iced something is all I am,
when my sweet shadow is wintering from me,
it's time to omen about, useful as elastic, and
finish my own acrobatics acrobatically. Meaning,
that some work shapes a season in a moment.
Other Gods keep no light or magic,
making hope awesomely unmetaphysical.
So take my omen, it
will plant enough seeds,
probably. If hours of nonsense know this sort of
watering, mouth filled like a snapdragon.
Leave needy patience nooked for now, and
make sure to leave out an adjective toy metaphor for me.

resilience

Time supposes symbols not angles.
By and by you will go where
all waves wait. First time pieces
like the first stair getting there.
Getting into it is another
night out along ten gritty rivers twice.
Grit goes out easy. It's only
irresistible, a surprisable coolness of spread out scissors.
To find your actual island
be without narration, chant something like shuffled rocks
a pocket ritual to get further
waiting no rescue, just as impossible
as France some empty while away.
Just gut it, fear is alway mind
weighed down by bits. Car borrowed and muscles bent,
your pocketable, enjoyable din.
Shimmy that here some.

connection

By surprising surprises
connection comes,
explosive or crooked or both. Here it also comes though these Carolina
times. Some academic and specialized
over a notch, just because I'm bringing my favorite brain.
While I still need for myself, just that I am
along bubbling emotional distance because she is
too judgemental. Generally, people are but it is
opening some hopefulness. They are also here by surprise.
And a time is also a story, something we move around like
a little fairy godmother sweeping all those ideas about.
Taking tables through some legs. Exploding a pillowstich mantra to
the sincere offer of some ridiculous hope.
To ever get through
and hope to know other people.

THE DETAILS

appendix

vocabulary

building the machine

the archive

credits

This list includes the participant's most frequently used words and the number of times each word was used throughout the project.

ERIN MCCABE

total words

4,758

ERIN MCCABE

vocabulary

it	133
my	83
is	57
be	41
there	38
all	36
just	36
you	34
me	32
magic	32
how	31
think	30
something	26
want	24
up	23
love	22
thing	21
time	21
little	20
sometime	20

BUILDING

the machine

The machine-writer collaboration behind CoPE combines the machine's recipe, or algorithm, with a writer's language-data. Each week, writers transformed their written responses into language-data (affectionately referred to as "fodder") for the machine. This machine-fodder collects certain aspects of the language, including the words themselves, word order, and parts-of-speech. The machine's central task is to build lines word by word, using a Markov Chain approach (creating a sequence of words in which the probability of each next-word depends on the previous word). The machine's selection of each next word is additionally connected to a particular part-of-speech. The parts-of-speech behind each participant's output poem is mapped to a sequence generated by the machine, which has been trained on over 15,000 poems from the Poetry Foundation website.

THE MACHINE

evolution process

Over the course of the six weeks, our experiment tested and evolved the machine's process in the following ways:

- More random selection based on parts-of-speech (sometimes ignoring fodder word-order)
- Improved word options by adding or eliminating different part-of-speech options of a given word (e.g. sever, severing / NOT severe)
- Specific language prompts based on prompt-poems (e.g. Begin a line with "Pain + verb")

Outputs were then limited to 80 - 120 words to generate participants' collaborative output poems.

THE ARCHIVE

poems poets prompts

The following section lists the theme, poem titles and authors, and corresponding expressive writing prompts delivered to participants each week.



WEEKLY
themes

Self
Uncertainty
Process
Pain
Resilience
Connection

self

Timeless

YUNG PUEBLO

Write to a past self.

How to Hold the Heavy Weight of the Now

DANA LEVIN

Describe something you'd like to
offer yourself.

After Opening The New York Times I Wonder How to Write a Poem about Love

CAMILLE T. DUNGY

Share a habit you walk around in.

Drinking There

MARK NEPO

Write about a secret joy.

I Am Young in My Love for the Moon

LEOPOLDINE CORE

I am young in my love for...

uncertainty

The Place Where We Are Right

YEHUDA AMICHAI

Write about the doubt and love
that dig up your world.

I Have No Idea What's Going to Happen

JUSTIN MARKS

Describe what has your attention
right now.

Funny

ANNA KAMIENSKA

Being human is...

The Couple in the Park

LOUISE GLUCK

Share about something that wasn't
what it seemed to be.

The Guest House

RUMI

Write a letter to today's
unexpected visitor.

poems / poets / prompts

process

Hurricane

MARY OLIVER

Write about the season you're in now.

On a Pink Moon

ADA LIMON

Describe the seeds you are planting.

How

HEID E. ERDICH

How...

breaklight

LUCILLE CLIFTON

Write about what took time to
understand.

Sweater

JANE HIRSHFIELD

Share what is taking shape in your life.

pain

Choices

TESS GALAGHER

Describe a pain that changed the way
you see.

What Pain Wants

SONYA HUBER

My pain wants...

Unending

SUSAN NGUYEN

Write about where you hold grief
in your body.

We Play Charades

UME MENON

Share a time you felt misunderstood.

Watching My Friend Pretend Her Heart Isn't Breaking

ROSEMERRY WAHTOLA TROMMER

Tell about a time your pain was met
with tenderness.

resilience

The Waking

THEODORE ROETHKE

Write what you learned by going where
you needed to go.

Let This Darkness Be a Bell Tower

RAINER MARIA RILKE

Describe the end of an uncontainable night.

When

GREGORY ORR

You had to change your footing when...

The Thing Is

ELLEN BASS

My body withstands...

Fairy Tale Logic

A.E. STALLINGS

Share what once seemed like an
impossible task.

connection

Context is all

ERICA HUNT

Write about someone who took you
by surprise.

The Wheel

SUSAN STOCKER

Bring back a time you felt loved and
describe the memory.

When Giving Is All We Have

ALBERTO RIOS

I give...

The World

ZAFFAR KUNIAL

Describe someone who holds you up.

Everything Lies in All Directions

HUA XI

Share something you're bringing with
you into the future.

2023

credits

The Machine

Erin McCabe

Dani Clark

Nova Ostermann

Clayton Belcher

Abby McGuire

Andrea Morrow

Chris Wagner

David Moody

Ebbi Bowen

Elmo Feiten

Harris Wheeler

Jason Bellmann

Lewis Thelen

Marcie Todd

Meg McCabe

Michael Clark

Myra Morehart

Nathan Overmann

Seth Gerke

Vicki Daiello



BOOKLET DESIGN

nova ostermann